

Reflection on “The Paranoid Style in American Politics” by Richard Hofstadter

Oliver Fischer

Hofstadter’s goal is to simply point out the significance of what he calls the paranoid style in politics, and its persistence throughout time. He clarifies that any group of people, anywhere and at any time can fall prey to this style. It’s a style that he describes as the belief of malice directed against an entire nation, rather than oneself as in clinical paranoia. He illuminates this by referring to several examples throughout American political history in which the paranoid style became prominent, such as the fear of the Bavarian Illuminati and their evil plot to overturn society itself. In reality of course, the Bavarian Illuminati was little more than a spawn of the French Revolution that followed the ideals of enlightenment.

While Hofstadter openly disapproves of the paranoid style, which is often characterized by an overwhelming evil force attempting to disrupt an established way of life, he admits that it is possible to bring forth valid issues under its guise. He uses fluoridation of water as an example. Paranoid style claimed it was an attempt to make people more vulnerable to communist schemes. Today this may sound bizarre, but the health concerns are a valid point. It stands to reason that behind every paranoid point lies a genuine issue worth discussing. But that issue tends to hide behind a veil of conspiracy theories. In fact, I sometimes feel like paranoid style is simply a euphemism for conspiracy theories.

Another element that Hofstadter attributes to the paranoid style is a sense of threat towards the (American) way of life. The basic formula doesn’t seem to change. It always revolves around a villain attempting to destroy the way of life as we know it. The villain changes every time, but his plan remains as evil and treacherous as ever.

One lingering question that remains unanswered is why American politics is so susceptible to the paranoid style. While Hofstadter specifies the global nature of the paranoid style, its prevalence in American politics remains intriguing. Perhaps the two-party system that promotes polarized thinking is to blame? After all, it’s a system that fosters the mentality of us vs. them, not just in politics but also in social life. Perhaps Americans feel more anxious about retaining what they have built, seeing that America is still a relatively young country?

Or perhaps the reason is more practical? I imagine the paranoid style can be quite effective in politics because many conspiracy theories paint an apocalyptic future, as was the case with the anti-Catholic movement. "It would not be long before some scion of the House of Habsburg would be installed as Emperor of the United States," writes Morse, joining the anti-Catholic mentality of 1835. Such a message can cause immense fear with the right demographic. Fear is an excellent motivator that is used time and time again to sway opinions. It is at this point that we can start drawing parallels with contemporary politics. President Trump is an excellent example of perpetuating the paranoid style. Consider the following statements he made:

"Many Gang Members and some very bad people are mixed into the Caravan heading to our Southern Border," he said. "The attacks on our police, and the terrorism in our cities, threaten our very way of life¹." At the start of his campaign, Trump insisted that Mexico is sending over rapists and criminals on purpose. These messages paint a dire future (one supposedly filled with rapists and criminals if nothing is done) and warn about the American way of life being in danger. Both are central traits in classic paranoid conspiracies.

But there is more. Hofstadter continues to describe the modern right and its increasingly tangible villains in the paranoid style. Indeed, this still holds true today, with the obscure Illuminati being replaced by Mexicans and other minority groups. One of Hofstadter's comparisons seems to confirm that the formula stays the same. It's just the variables that change in the paranoid style. In the old days, the country was supposedly infused with Jesuit agents. Then it was communist agents. Now it's Mexican rapists and criminals.

Or perhaps it is all much simpler. Humans tend to look for simple explanations, and the easier the explanation, the more convenient, the more inclined we are to believe it. And what could be easier and more convenient than blaming all your problems on a single person or group of people?

¹ <https://www.cnn.com/2018/10/30/politics/donald-trump-immigration/index.html>